



The Friend I Did Not Lose

Teacher copy (everything in the student copy, plus answers and teaching notes)

The article, marked for rhetorical devices (one color throughout):

1 There is a contact in my phone I have not called in four years, and I scrolled past her name this morning the way you step around a chair you keep meaning to move. We used to talk three times a week. Now I could not tell you the city she lives in without guessing, and I would guess wrong.

2 I want to be careful with the word lose, because it is the one everyone reaches for and it is wrong. Nobody took her. We did not fight. There was no last conversation that anyone would recognize as a last one, no door, no slam, just a slow widening of the most ordinary kind: shared activity, nearness, and steady contact hold a friendship up, and when those go, the bond does not break so much as quietly thin. She moved for a job. I had a kid. Competing demands did the rest.

3 A dorm hallway is exactly the kind of place these friendships tend to start and exactly the kind of bond that tends to thin once the place that made it is gone [Parallelism]. I did not know that at nineteen. Being known like that feels permanent, like a thing you own rather than a thing you are standing inside of for a while [Simile]. I owned nothing. I was a guest in a season of her life and she in mine.

4 Here is what took me a decade to believe. Your circle of friends actually shrinks in your thirties and forties, and that shrinking is not coldness but a sorting, the mind spending less time on more meaning as the runway ahead gets shorter [Cumulative and periodic sentences]. I have fewer friends now. The ones I have, I would drive through the night for. She is not one of them anymore, and both of those sentences are true.

5 Because it was grief. The strange kind, the kind nobody brings a casserole for, with no real ritual to mark it [Imagery]. My grandmother kept buttons in a tin that smelled like pennies. Grief over a person who is alive and well is a quieter thing, and quieter does not mean smaller.

6 So I have stopped saying I lost her. What I mean is that the friendship finished, the way a good book finishes. Letting the distance be what it was, instead of forcing contact to fight it, is what keeps the memory of her good and keeps the resentment out. She was a real part of one stretch of my life.

7 I do not need her back. I need to have been her friend, which already happened, which nothing now can undo. The tin is still in a drawer somewhere. I keep meaning to find it.

Devices, and why they are here:

Parallelism (paragraph 3): “A dorm hallway is exactly the kind of place these friendships tend to start and exactly the kind of bond that tends to thin once the place that made it is gone”

The twinned frame, exactly the kind of place and exactly the kind of bond, sets the beginning and the unraveling of the friendship in the same grammatical shape, so the reader feels the start and the end as one motion; the repeated structure does the work without the writer having to explain that the thing that made the bond is also what undid it.

Simile (paragraph 3): “like a thing you own rather than a thing you are standing inside of for a while”
The explicit comparison, signaled by like, sets a friendship you own against a place you are only standing inside of, making the writer's young error in belonging concrete; choosing the open like rather than a buried metaphor lets the reader hear the comparison plainly and feel the mistake before it is named.

Cumulative and periodic sentences (paragraph 4): “Your circle of friends actually shrinks in your thirties and forties, and that shrinking is not coldness but a sorting, the mind spending less time on more meaning as the runway ahead gets shorter”

This is the cumulative (front-loaded) form: the main clause arrives first (the circle shrinks) and the sentence then adds member after member, the correction and the reason, so the reader experiences the mind doing the very sorting it describes; the loose accumulation matches the thinking-aloud Witness Stand voice against the short lines around it.

Imagery (paragraph 5): “The strange kind, the kind nobody brings a casserole for, with no real ritual to mark it”

The concrete picture of a grief no one brings a casserole for turns an abstract claim about unrecognized loss into something the reader can see and almost smell; the homely sensory detail carries the feeling, so the writer never has to assert that the loss is sad.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. In the second paragraph, the writer insists on rejecting the word lose primarily to
 - A) accuse the friend of having abandoned the relationship without explanation
 - B) reframe the ending of the friendship as a gradual thinning rather than a loss someone caused
 - C) prove that most adult friendships are destroyed by a single decisive argument
 - D) argue that the word lose should never be used about people who are still alive
2. In context, the closing image of the tin the writer keeps meaning to find best supports which characterization of the writer's tone?
 - A) detached indifference toward a relationship the writer no longer cares about
 - B) settled acceptance that values what the friendship was without needing to act on it now
 - C) wistful regret that the writer failed to keep the friendship alive
 - D) anxious urgency to recover something before it is lost for good

Multiple choice answer key:

1. Answer B. The paragraph replaces the language of breakage with a slow widening in which the bond does not break so much as quietly thin, which is exactly the redefinition the writer is performing. The option about the friend abandoning the relationship inverts the writer's stance, since the paragraph stresses no fight and no one taken. The option about a decisive argument states the opposite of the passage, which insists there was no last conversation. The option forbidding the word for living people is over-broad, extending a personal correction into an absolute rule the text never makes.

2. Answer B. By this point the writer has said the friendship finished like a good book and that having been the friend already happened and cannot be undone, so the unhurried image of a tin still in a drawer rests on contentment rather than longing. Wistful regret misreads a piece that explicitly says I do not need her back. Detached indifference contradicts the care the writer takes with the memory, since he keeps the tin and keeps meaning to find it. Anxious urgency misreads the slow, untroubled phrasing of keep meaning to as alarm, when the passage has just removed the fear of loss.

Discussion questions:

1. The writer spends the whole piece refusing the word lose and proposing other words for it (finished, thinned, a season). Which substitute best fits what the passage actually describes, and what does each word ask the reader to feel that the others do not?
2. The narrator says two sentences can both be true: that the friend is no longer close, and that the writer would drive through the night for the friends who remain. How does the piece earn the right to hold two feelings at once instead of resolving into either nostalgia or bitterness?

Sample strong discussion responses:

1. The strongest substitute is finished, because the writer pairs it with the image of a good book ending, which carries no blame and no incompleteness. Lose implies someone is at fault or something was stolen, and the passage works hard to remove both ideas: nobody took her, there was no fight. Thinned is accurate but passive, describing the mechanism (less contact, less nearness) more than the meaning. Season is the warmest of the three, but on its own it could sound dismissive, as if the friend were merely a phase. Finished does the most work because it grants the friendship a real beginning, middle, and end, which is the dignity the writer is trying to restore. The choice of word is the argument; redefining the loss as a completed thing is how the writer reframes belonging itself.
2. The piece earns the double feeling by anchoring each side to something concrete rather than stating it. The fondness is carried by physical detail (the dorm hallway, the tin that smelled like pennies, driving through the night), so the reader feels the bond was real. The distance is carried by equally plain facts (a contact not called in four years, not knowing her city), so the reader feels the gap without melodrama. Crucially the writer names the temptation to collapse the two and then refuses it, letting the grief be grief and the gratitude be gratitude. By holding both rather than choosing, the narrator models the maturity the passage describes, and the piece closes without tidying the feeling into a single verdict.

Writing prompt (Homework or extended in-class, Q2 rhetorical analysis):

The following passage is a first-person reflection on the quiet ending of a long friendship. Read the passage carefully. Then write an essay that analyzes the rhetorical choices the writer makes to develop a reframing of what it means to lose a friend. In your response you should do the following: respond to the prompt with a defensible thesis that analyzes the writer's rhetorical choices; select and use evidence to support your line of reasoning; explain how the evidence supports your line of reasoning; and demonstrate an understanding of the rhetorical situation. Consider how the writer's diction (especially the contested word lose), figurative language, sentence structure, and use of concrete personal detail work together to move the reader from the language of breakage toward the language of completion.

Common misconceptions to watch for:

- Students may treat the twinned dorm-hallway construction in paragraph 3 as ordinary scene-setting and miss that it functions as parallelism (device 1): exactly the kind of place and exactly the kind of bond carry the start and the unraveling of the friendship in one matched grammatical shape, so the structure itself argues that what made the bond is what undid it.
- Students often label the comparison in paragraph 3 (belonging as a thing you own versus a place you stand inside of) a metaphor because it sounds figurative. The sentence carries the explicit word like, which makes it a simile by the controlled-list definition (device 2). This is a classic simile-versus-metaphor look-alike check: the presence of like settles it.
- Students may read the piece as an argument that the writer was wronged or that the friend is to blame. The passage explicitly removes a culprit (nobody took her, no fight, competing demands did the rest), so reading blame into it is the inverted-relationship trap and misses that the grief here has no villain.
- Students may assume grief requires death and therefore conclude the writer is exaggerating. The piece (and the cited loss literature) treats grief over a living, well friend as real but culturally unmarked; the casserole image in paragraph 5 (device 4, imagery) shows the loss precisely by picturing the ritual that is missing.

AP exam alignment:

This opener gives students a compact first-person argument-by-redefinition to analyze, foregrounding how diction (the contested word lose), figurative language, and concrete personal detail can reframe an abstract idea rather than assert it. It exercises Style (how word choice and tone serve purpose) and Claims and Evidence (tracking a position advanced through anecdote), and it models the rhetorical-analysis task of explaining how specific choices move a reader, making it well suited to a Q2 free-response.